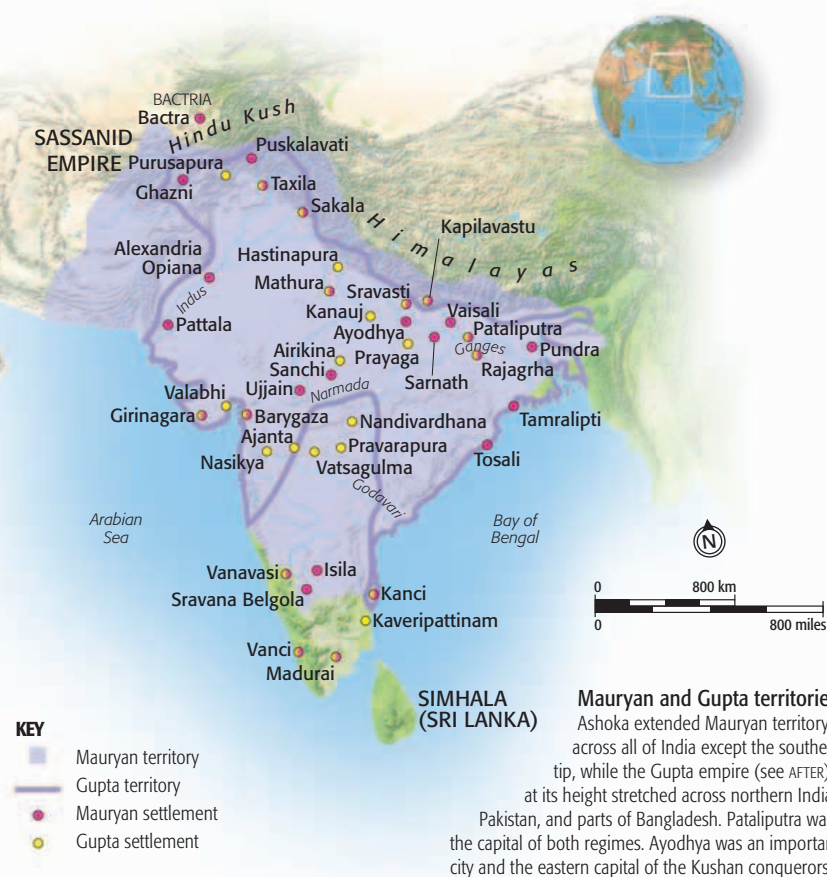




BEFORE

The Vedic period (c. 1500–500 BCE) is named after the Vedas—ancient Indo-Aryan texts that were produced during this time and that are central to the Hindu faith.

EARLY VEDIC PERIOD

Many local dynasties came into being, and by the 8th century BCE, India was divided into many small, competing kingdoms.

LATE VEDIC PERIOD

Around the 8th century BCE, large urban states known as *mahajanapadas* started to take shape in northern India. The northeastern **Magadha** area came to dominate the various warring regional powers. Its strategic position in the Ganges valley aided trade and linked it with flourishing ports in the Ganges river delta.

NANDA DYNASTY

In the 5th century BCE, just a few states, including Magadha, dominated India. By the 4th century, after countless wars, Magadha had emerged as the most powerful. Ruled by the prosperous **Nanda dynasty**, it set up complex irrigation projects and an efficient administration system, built a strong army, and established a royal center at the city of **Pataliputra** (modern Patna).

RISING RELIGIONS

Jainism and **Buddhism 144–47** were well established by the 4th century BCE, gaining ground against Vedic traditions—the origin of Hinduism.

India's First Empire

From their northeastern heartland, the Mauryans came to dominate India's massive subcontinent with what became its first real empire. This reached its greatest extent and enjoyed its greatest cultural flowering under the rule of Ashoka, who also played a major part in the rise of the Buddhist religion.

Around 321 BCE, the Nanda dynasty (see BEFORE) was toppled by Chandragupta Maurya, founder of the Mauryan dynasty and what would become the great Mauryan empire (c. 321–185 BCE). The emperor Chandragupta won a great deal of new territory, combining smaller kingdoms and uniting—often rather loosely—vast regions of India

under one ruler for the first time. The empire embraced much of the Indian subcontinent and part of Afghanistan.

The lands into which Chandragupta expanded included parts of the Macedonian empire won by Alexander (see pp.96–99) and by his successors the Seleucids. The Seleucids' attempts to repeat Alexander's success brought them headlong into the path of the advancing Mauryans, but Seleucus I Nicator ceded his claims to lands around the Indus in a pact with Chandragupta in 305 BCE.

Hellenistic (Greek) culture continued to have an influence in northern India, while Chandragupta based his administration partly on the Persian Achaemenid model (see pp.92–93). His highly efficient and impressive centralized system also owed much

to his minister, Chanakya, who produced one of the greatest treatises on politics, administration, and economics ever written—*Arthashastra*.

Chandragupta's legacy

At the core of Chandragupta's newly won empire was its glittering capital at Pataliputra. Under his sure hand, backed by strong military resources and an effective secret service, agriculture and trade flourished. He died around 297 BCE, having fasted to death. As a convert to Jainism, he spent his final days in ascetic repentance for a terrible famine that struck his people, which he was grief-stricken at being unable to hold back.

The second emperor was Chandragupta's son, Bindusara (c. 297–265 BCE). Little is known of his reign, but it seems



Ashoka pillar

This is one of Ashoka's famous polished sandstone pillars bearing edicts inscribed in Brahmi script to help spread his ideas among his people. They are among the oldest deciphered original Indian texts.



The Ashoka lions

Ashoka made this four-lion motif his symbol of imperial authority; it is now used as India's official emblem.